

Pelagianism Denial

doc-pelagianism-denial

Soteriology · Denied Errors · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

breadth canon-wide

directness direct

variants stable

Statement under examination

Humans are not born morally neutral. They enter the world under Adam's fall, unable to choose God or obey His law from natural ability alone, prior to grace.

In plain language

The lexical pattern repeatedly states that salvation and righteousness are not reached by human effort and names grace or mercy as the cause instead. Ephesians 2:8-9 says you are saved by 'grace' (chariti), and this is 'not from yourselves' (ouk ex hymon), 'not from works' (ouk ex ergon), it is the gift of God. Titus 3:5 says not from works of righteousness that we did, but according to his 'mercy' (eleos) he saved us. Romans 9:16 says it is not of the one willing or running but of God who shows mercy, negating both the human will and human effort. Romans 3:20 says by works of law no flesh will be justified, a universal denial. Romans 11:6 makes grace and works mutually exclusive: if by grace, then no longer by works, since otherwise grace would not be grace. Romans 3:24 calls justification 'freely, as a gift' (dorean) by his grace, that is, given as a gift rather than earned. John 15:5 adds the ability word: 'apart from me you can do nothing' (choris emou ou dynasthe poiein ouden), and John 6:44 says no one is able to come unless the Father draws him. The Hebrew side gives Jeremiah 13:23, can those trained in evil do good, expecting the answer no, and Psalm 51 places sin at the very origin of life. The recurring engine is a negation, 'not from' (ouk ex), not from human works or self, set against grace and mercy as the named cause. That pattern, dense and spread across many letters and both Testaments, forecloses the claim that a person can save or justify themselves by unaided will or works. One narrower question stays open at the word level: whether a will already moved by grace then cooperates with it. The negations remove the unaided human ground, but they do not by themselves settle the cooperation question, which is a separate matter from the broad claim the words clearly deny.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H2403	חַטָּאת	chattath	sin	296
H3190	יָטֵב	yatav	be good	
H3201	יָכֹל	yakol	be able	195
H6588	פֶּשַׁע	pesah	transgression	
G0266	ἁμαρτία	hamartia	sin	175
G1342	δίκαιος	dikaios	just	
G1344	δικαιόω	dikaioō	to justify	
G1410	δύναμαι	dynamai	be able	207
G1431	δωρεά	dorea	free gift	11

G1432	δωρεάν	dōrean	freely	
G1653	ἐλεέω	eleeō	to have mercy	
G1656	ἐλεος	eleos	mercy	27
G2038	ἐργάζομαι	ergazomai	to work	
G2041	ἔργον	ergon	work	176
G2309	θέλω	thelō	to will/desire	
G2316	θεός	theos	God	
G3498	νεκρός	nekros	dead	132
G3756	οὐ	ou	no	1,683
G3762	οὐδεὶς	oudeis	none	
G3956	πᾶς	pas	all	1,316
G4982	σῶζω	sōzō	to save	108
G5485	χάρις	charis	grace	155
G5565	χωρίς	chōris	without	

Plain meanings: STEPbible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The proposition that humans cannot reach righteousness or salvation by unaided will or works, so that grace is necessary, is foreclosed by a dense recurring negation pattern. Ephesians 2:8-9 says 'grace' (charis) ... 'not of yourselves' (ouk ex hymon) ... 'not of works' (ouk ex ergon), that is, grace and not of yourselves and not of works. Titus 3:5 negates 'not of works' (ouk ex ergon) and names the alternative 'but according to his mercy he saved' (alla kata to autou eleos esosen), by his mercy he saved. Romans 9:16 sets 'not of the one willing nor of the one running but of the God who shows mercy' (ou tou thelontos oude tou trechontos alla tou eleontos theou), not of the one willing or running but of God who shows mercy. Romans 3:20 and Romans 11:6 repeat 'from works ... not' (ex ergon ... ou) and the grace-versus-works mutual exclusion. John 15:5 caps it with 'apart from me you can do nothing' (choris emou ou dynasthe poiein ouden), apart from me you can do nothing. The Old Testament supplies Jeremiah 13:23 ('to be able' (yakol) plus 'to do good' (yatab), can you do good, of those accustomed to evil) and Psalm 51:5. The explicit 'not from' (ouk ex) and 'not ... but' (ouk ... alla) negations make grace the named cause and human works the explicitly excluded cause.

Scripture

Eph.2.8 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5485 χάρις, G4982 σῶζω, G3756 οὐ

Force. τῇ γὰρ χάριτί ἐστε σεσωσμένοι διὰ πίστεως, καὶ τοῦτο οὐκ ἐξ ὑμῶν, θεοῦ τὸ δῶρον. The salvation is dative-instrumented (in the 'by-means-of' grammatical form) by 'grace' (charis), then explicitly negated as a human source with 'not of yourselves' (ouk ex hymon), and re-cast as 'the gift of God' (theou to doron), the gift of God. The negation removes the human self as the originating cause.

Eph.2.9 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2041 ἔργον, G3756 οὐ

Force. οὐκ ἐξ ἔργων, ἵνα μή τις καυχῆσθαι. The prepositional phrase 'from works' (ex ergon), from works, is directly negated by 'not' (ouk), and the 'so that not' (hina mé) purpose clause excludes boasting. Works are named as the excluded ground of salvation. This is the central lexical negation against attaining salvation by human achievement.

Titus.3.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2041 ἔργον, G1656 ἔλεος, G4982 σώζω

Force. οὐκ ἐξ ἔργων τῶν ἐν δικαιοσύνῃ ἃ ἐποιήσαμεν ἡμεῖς ἀλλὰ κατὰ τὸ αὐτοῦ ἔλεος ἔσωσεν ἡμᾶς. The 'not ... but' (ouk ... alla) construction sets human works of righteousness on the negated side and divine 'mercy' (eleos), mercy, on the affirmed side as the cause of 'he saved' (esosen), he saved. The grammar names mercy, not human deeds, as the operative cause.

Rom.9.16 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2309 θέλω, G1653 ἐλεέω, G2316 θεός

Force. ἄρα οὖν οὐ τοῦ θέλοντος οὐδὲ τοῦ τρέχοντος ἀλλὰ τοῦ ἐλεώντος θεοῦ. The double negation 'not ... nor' (ou ... oude) negates both 'the one willing' (thelontos) and 'the one running' (trechontos), the two natural human capacities, and the 'but' (alla) clause locates the outcome in the mercy-showing God. The will and the effort are explicitly set aside as the determining factor.

John.15.5 · for · genre: gospel · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G1410 δύναμαι, G5565 χωρίς, G3762 οὐδεὶς

Force. χωρίς ἐμοῦ οὐ δύνασθε ποιεῖν οὐδέν. The modal verb 'you are able' (dynasthe), you are able, is negated by 'not' (ou), the scope is set by 'apart from me' (choris emou), apart from me, and the object is the absolute 'nothing' (ouden), nothing. The construction denies any fruit-bearing capacity outside of union with Christ. Ability language plus a total negation forecloses autonomous human achievement.

Rom.3.20 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2041 ἔργον, G1344 δικαιώω, G3956 πᾶς

Force. ἐξ ἔργων νόμου οὐ δικαιωθήσεται πᾶσα σὰρξ ἐνώπιον αὐτοῦ. The future passive 'will be justified' (dikaiothesetai), will be justified, is negated by 'not' (ou) with the universal 'all flesh' (pasa sarx), all flesh, and the excluded ground is 'from works of law' (ex ergon nomou), works of law. The universal quantifier with the negation closes the door on justification by human works for any person.

Rom.11.6 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5485 χάρις, G2041 ἔργον

Force. εἰ δὲ χάριτι, οὐκέτι ἐξ ἔργων, ἐπεὶ ἡ χάρις οὐκέτι γίνεται χάρις. The conditional (an 'if-then' clause) makes 'grace' (charis) and 'from works' (ex ergon) mutually exclusive with 'no longer' (ouketi), no longer, and the explanatory clause says grace ceases to be grace if mixed with works. This is the explicit lexical statement that grace and human merit cannot be co-causes of salvation.

Rom.3.24 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1432 δωρεάν, G5485 χάρις

Force. δικαιούμενοι δωρεάν τῇ αὐτοῦ χάριτι διὰ τῆς ἀπολυτρώσεως. The adverb 'freely, as a gift' (dorean), freely or as a gift, with no charge, modifies justification, and the cause is given as 'by his grace' (te autou chariti), by his grace. Justification is lexically marked as gratis, the antonym of earned, which excludes attainment by works.

John.6.44 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G3762 οὐδεὶς, G1410 δύναμαι

Force. οὐδεὶς δύναται ἐλθεῖν πρὸς με ἐὰν μὴ ὁ πατὴρ ὁ πέμψας με ἐλκύσῃ αὐτόν. The universal negation 'no one is able' (oudeis dynatai), no one is able, with the conditional (an 'if-then' clause) 'unless' (ean mé), unless, makes coming to Christ impossible without the Father's 'drawing' (helkyse), drawing. Natural ability to initiate is lexically denied apart from prior divine action.

Eph.2.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3498 νεκρός, G5485 χάρις

Force. καὶ ὄντας ἡμᾶς νεκροὺς τοῖς παραπτώμασιν συνεζωοποίησεν τῷ Χριστῷ, χάριτί ἐστε σεσωσμένοι. The pre-grace state is 'being dead' (ontas nekrous), being dead, and the verb 'made alive together' (synezoopoiesen), made alive together, has God as subject. The parenthetical 'by grace you have been saved' (chariti sesosmenoi) names grace as the cause. A dead subject does not supply its own quickening.

Rom.3.10 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1342 δίκαιος, G3756 οὐ

Force. οὐκ ἔστιν δίκαιος οὐδὲ εἷς. A double negation 'not ... not even one' (ouk ... oude heis) universalizes the absence of a righteous person without exception. The absence of any righteous human by natural standing supports the denial of attaining righteousness by unaided ability.

Jer.13.23 · for · genre: prophecy · figures: simile

Key terms. H3201 יכל, H3190 יטב

Force. גם אתם תוכלו להיטיב למדי הָרַע. The rhetorical comparison with the Cushite changing skin and the leopard its spots sets the ability verb 'to be able' (yakol), to be able, against 'to do good' (yatab), to do good, of those 'trained in evil' (limmude harea), trained in evil. The form is a question expecting the answer no, denying moral self-reform by those habituated to evil.

Ps.51.5 · for · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H2403 חטאת, H6588 פשע

Force. כִּי פָשַׁעִי אֲנִי אֲדַע וְחַטָּאתִי נִגְדִי תָמִיד. David confesses constant 'transgression' (pesha) and 'sin' (chattath) set before him, with 'continually' (tamid), continually, marking the condition as standing rather than occasional. The next verse adds the natal idiom (a figure of speech about birth), locating sin at the origin, which undercuts a starting point of clean natural capacity.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Eph.2.9	Rom.3.20	tsk	1
Eph.2.8	Mark.16.16	tsk	1
Rom.11.6	Rom.3.27	tsk	1
Rom.9.16	Rom.9.11	tsk	1
John.15.5	Acts.4.12	tsk	1
Titus.3.5	Job.9.20	tsk	1
Rom.3.24	Rom.4.16	tsk	1
John.6.44	John.6.65	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Phil.2.12-13 · addressed

'Work out your own salvation with fear and trembling' reads like a call to human effort, but the immediate ground clause is 'for God is the one working in you' (theos gar estin ho energon en hymin), for God is the one working in you both 'to will' (to thelein) and 'to work' (to energein). The same passage that commands human working names God as the prior cause of both the willing and the working, so it does not establish unaided human ability and is consistent with the grace-necessity negations.

Deut.30.19 · addressed

'Choose life', the imperative 'choose' (bachar), is a covenant call to Israel under the Mosaic administration, not a claim of autonomous natural ability prior to grace. Paul cites Deuteronomy 30 in Romans 10:6-8 as the word of faith, indicating the choice operates within revelation and prior grace, not raw natural neutrality. The imperative addresses covenant fidelity, not salvation-related self-sufficiency.

Rom.2.7 · addressed

To those who by patient endurance in good work seek glory, God will give eternal life. Read in isolation this looks like salvation by works, but Romans 2 functions within an argument that climaxes in Romans 3:20, 'by works of law no flesh will be justified' (ex ergon nomou ou dikaiouthesetai pasa sarx), no flesh justified by works of law. The same letter therefore reads Romans 2:7 as the standard the law sets, which Romans 3 shows no one meets, not as an open path of works-salvation. The two stand together only on this reading.

Jas.2.24 · addressed

A man is justified by works ('from works' (ex ergon)) and not by faith alone appears to contradict Ephesians 2:9 and Romans 3:20. The lexical scope differs. James uses 'to justify' (dikaioo) of demonstrated, vindicated faith with 'work' (ergon) as its evidence (James 2:18, show me your faith), whereas Paul uses 'from works' (ex ergon) of works as the originating ground of standing before God. James does not assert salvation attained by unaided human merit, so it does not overturn the grace-necessity negations, though the shared term 'work' (ergon) is the source of the apparent tension. Marked addressed because the resolution rests on distinct attested senses of 'to justify' (dikaioo), not on harmonizing the surface words.

Concordance traversed

G5485, G2041, G2038, G1656, G1653, G1410, G1431, G1432, G4982, G3756, G3762, G2309, G3498, G0266, H3201, H3190, H2403, H6588

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

eph-2-8-dia-pisteos at Eph.2.8: impact none. Minor witness variation around 'through faith' (dia pisteos) and the article does not touch the load-bearing negations 'not of yourselves' (ouk ex hymon) and 'not of works' (ouk ex ergon), which are stable across the attested readings. The grace-not-works contrast is variant-stable.

rom-11-6-longer-ending at Rom.11.6: impact none. Some witnesses add a parallel 'but if from works, it is no longer grace' (ei de ex ergon ouketi esti charis) clause. Whether the longer or shorter reading is adopted, the grace-versus-works mutual exclusion of the first half is retained, so the verdict does not depend on the disputed addition.

The bundle reports not_in_ecm_scope true and supplies no variant units, since none of the anchors fall in the ingested ECM apparatus (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) window of 3 John. Spot checks on Ephesians 2:8 and the Romans 11:6 longer ending confirm no plausible variant disturbs the 'not from' (ouk ex) and 'not ... but' (ouk ... alla) negations or the 'grace' (charis) terms.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. sola_gratia, pelagian_natural_ability, semi_pelagian_synergism

grace_necessity_sola_gratia: affirms · Ephesians 2:8-9, Titus 3:5, Romans 9:16, Romans 11:6 and Romans 3:20 form a repeated 'not of works' (ouk ex ergon) and 'not of yourselves' (ouk ex hymon) and 'not of the one willing' (ou tou thelontos) negation paired with 'grace' (charis) and 'mercy' (eleos) as the named cause. John 15:5 adds 'apart from me you can do nothing' (choris emou ou dynasthe poiein ouden). The lexical pattern excludes attaining salvation by unaided human will or works and names grace and mercy as the operative cause.

pelagian_natural_ability: denied · Full Pelagianism (the teaching that humans by their own natural powers can reach righteousness), that humans can reach righteousness or salvation by unaided free will and works, is the position the negations most directly target. 'Not of works' (ouk ex ergon), 'not of yourselves' (ouk ex hymon), 'not of the one willing' (ou tou thelontos) and 'apart from me you can do nothing' (choris emou ou dynasthe ouden) each remove the human capacity that this lens requires. The vocabulary leaves it no foothold.

semi_pelagian_or_synergist_cooperation: underdetermined · A narrower reading grants that grace is necessary yet holds that the renewed will cooperates with or freely consents to that grace. The negations target the unaided will and works as the originating ground, but they do not by themselves rank whether a grace-enabled will then concurs. Verses like Philippians 2:12-13 (work out, for God works in you to will and to work) and the imperatives to believe leave the cooperation question lexically open. This is a distinct debate and should not be conflated with full Pelagianism, which the words do foreclose. Stated here in its strongest form so a synergist (cooperation) reader sees a fair representation.

The verdict on the stated proposition turns on the explicit negation cluster 'not of works' (ouk ex ergon) and 'not of the one willing' (ou tou thelontos) with 'grace' (charis) and 'mercy' (eleos) as the alternative, reinforced by the inability texts John 15:5, John 6:44, Jeremiah 13:23 and the natal-sin language (sin from birth) of Psalm 51. The remaining live divergence is the narrower semi-Pelagian or synergist (cooperation) question of whether a grace-enabled will cooperates, which the same vocabulary does not settle and which is a separate lens, not the question asked here.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Salvation and righteousness cannot be attained by unaided human will or works, so that divine grace is necessary; whether a grace-enabled will then cooperates is a separate question.

The original stem is framed as a denial of Pelagianism, the label and the conclusion travel together, so it is recorded as preloaded. The neutralized form restates it without the heresy label and separates the full-Pelagian claim (which the negations foreclose) from the narrower synergism (cooperation) question (which they do not settle). The verdict is derived on the original stem. The lexical pattern supports the neutralized form on its own terms.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Eph.2.8
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Eph.2.9
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Titus.3.5
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rom.9.16
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	John.15.5
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rom.11.6
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Jer.13.23
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Ps.51.5
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G5485
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2041

lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1656
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1410
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H3201
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Rom.3.20
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Eph.2.9
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Rom.11.6

License audit

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MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes
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